

A Study on the Functions and Roles of Cutscenes : Focusing on the Case of Biohazard RE:2

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1. Introduction

The question of whether the story or rules of a game have a more significant impact on player experience has been an ongoing debate within the academic community. However, taken to their extremes, both theories do not provide a complete understanding of games. The current state of "story-driven" video games exists at the intersection of both theories, preventing us from viewing video games solely narrative or ludological.[1] Cutscenes function as a tool to seamlessly integrate gameplay and narrative[2].

A study focusing on these functions of cutscenes is exemplified by the research of Newman, Cheng, and Arsenopoulou et al. Newman categorizes cutscenes into four main functions: explaining objectives, mechanics, interface, and saving progress.[3] Cheng identifies six uses, including save points, breaks, feedback, rewards, and story advancement by developing the lists of Newman.[1] Arsenopoulou et al. further classify cutscenes as checkpoints for significant game moments, such as introduction, finales, and major battles[4]. This study aims to categorize cutscene usage patterns by integrating the findings from the three prior studies.

2. Cutscenes: A cinematic technique for storytelling

A cinematic game is a game that deeply integrates cinematic direction and narrative structure into its gameplay. Since games have a non-linear narrative structure, various cinematic devices are used for driving the story forward. The most popular of these are cutscenes. Cinematics cutscenes are pre-rendered or scripted sequences using a combination of animation, visual effects, and audio to depict specific part of the game's narrative.[5] The standard distinction between gameplay and cutscenes is that the former is "active" or "interactive," while the latter is "passive." [1] Immersion in a game is about the player controlling the action. Many video games are played from a first-person perspective or back view of the character. Cutscenes, on the other hand, show the character from multiple angles and do not allow the player to intervene. It is a cinematic adaptation of a game. Video games have become more cinematic, appealing to audiences outside of their original intended audience.[4]

3. Cutscene usage and role in Biohazard RE:2

Biohazard RE:2 is a reimagining game of Resident Evil 2, which released on 2019. It serves a story after a viral outbreak at the Spencer Mansion rendering its inhabitants zombified bioweapons, the virus has spread to Raccoon City. This reimagining game sold 7.2 million copies, outselling the original.[6] The Leon A route in Biohazard RE:2 features a total of 50 cutscenes and 43 interactive gameplay elements.

The game was analyzed by the roles of cutscenes based on the classifications by Newman, Cheng, and Arsenopoulou et al., The analysis identified the presence of several cutscene functions within the game, including "spatial movement and checkpoints," "mission presentation," and "item acquisition and description" from Newman's list[3]; "world-building explanation" from Cheng's list[1]; and "opening and finale" and "introduction and conclusion of major events" from Arsenopoulou et al.'s list[4]. Notably, Biohazard RE:2 also exhibits three cutscene usage patterns not previously discussed in the aforementioned literature: "character introductions and farewells," "emphasizing mood," and "character control switching." The table below provides examples of each cutscene type and examples.

Table 1: Types and examples of cutscenes in Biohazard RE:2

No.	Type	Example
1	Spatial movement and checkpoints [3]	Cutscene 7. Leon arrives at the police station and locks the gates.
2	Mission presentation[3]	Cutscene 21. The reporter tells Leon to exchange a key card and escape.
3	Item acquisition and explanation[3]	Cutscene 23. The clock is repaired, the bell rings, and a box is dropped. Cutscene 47. Someone gives Leon a rocket launcher.
4	Universe explanation[1]	Cutscene 4. A police officer gets his throat bitten off by someone.
5	Introduction and conclusion of major events[4]	Cutscene 40. Annette traps Leon and William. Cutscene 41. William collapses.
6	Opening and finale[4]	Cutscene 1. A driver hits a woman on the road. The driver checks on the

		woman. The dead woman gets up from behind the driver. Cutscene 50. Leon throws his ID band off the train and misses Ada. The monster's tentacles are visible between the doors at the back of train.
7	Character introduction and farewell	Cutscene 5. Claire opens the gas station door, and Leon shoots the zombie. Cutscene 6. A truck crashes into Leon and Claire's car, causing them to be separated.
8	Atmosphere emphasis	Cutscene 13. Leon examines the officer with the torn jaw. Cutscene 26. The gun shop owner's daughter is infected. The owner asks Leon and Ada to leave him and his daughter alone. Gunshots are heard from inside.
9	Manipulative character switching	Cutscene 28. Leon gets shot by Anette instead of Ada. Cutscene 29. Ada gets on the radio with someone.

Three additional items indicate that cutscenes are integrally connected to interactions. Cutscenes used for "Character introductions and farewells" enable the smooth transitions and seamless gameplay for appearance and exit of non-playable characters. In "Emphasizing Mood," certain cutscenes are selectively triggered by player interaction, enhancing atmosphere while remaining outside direct narrative progression. "Manipulative Character Switching," such as transitions between Leon and Ada, supports story progression and alleviates gameplay monotony, providing players with new objectives and fostering a multilayered understanding of the narrative.

4. Conclusion

This study reviewed previous research on the function of cutscenes and identified cutscenes that effectively support storytelling in games. Based on this foundation, the cutscenes and interactions in Biohazard RE:2 was examined to understand the usage of cutscenes. As a result, three additional uses of cutscenes: "Character introductions and farewells," "Emphasizing mood," and "Manipulative Character Switching" were found, in addition to the six existing functions of "Opening and finale," "Universe explanation," "Spatial movement and checkpoints," "Presenting missions," "Item acquisition and explanation," and "Introduction and conclusion of major events" identified in previous studies. Building upon this study, subsequent research may investigate the generalizability of these cutscene classifications across diverse game contexts and develop a game design model in which cutscenes and player interactions are cohesively integrated to optimize the player experience.

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6. References

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